

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*The Gospel of Life ~
The Gospel According to Antoni Gaudí
September 28th, 2025*



Sagrada Família, Barcelona

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on TALLIS' CANON and CWM RHONDDA

Kyrie from *Missa Orbis Factor* / Toccata Deo Gratias (Richard Keys Biggs)

Invention in C minor (William Joel)

Fugue in Eb Major, BWV 552/2 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Excerpts of "Closer To Heaven", "Inside Looking Out" and "La Sagrada Familia" from *Gaudi*
by The Alan Parsons Project (Woolfson/Parsons)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Michael Lehman & Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the Holy One,
who is infinitely greater than words can express,
and yet is the Heart of our hearts,
and the Mind of our minds,
and whose love for us and all creation,
exceeds our capacity to imagine.

We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the Holy Oneness,
the web of life that holds all beings in intimate embrace,
making it possible to distinguish but never disconnect
any part from the whole,
conferring kinship
in the kin-dom of God.

We open now to Sacred Mystery,
that was and is and always shall be before our face,
before we were born, before the glorious becoming began.

*In hope, we open to you,
Ever-evolving Thou of all creation.
In awe, we open to the Great Unity.
In humility, we open to the Sacred of the Universe,
as we embrace our future with hope.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

God of Change and God of Glory

CWM RHONDDA

God of change and God of glory, God of time and God of space,
When we fear our future story, give to us your loving grace.
Grant us wisdom, grant us courage, give us still the gift to praise,
Give us still the gift to praise.

God of many different colors, God of many different signs,
You have made all of us different, blessings for all humankind.
Grant us wisdom, grant us courage, let your love cast out our fear,
Let your love cast out our fear.

Freshness of the light of morning, freshness of the light of night,
You are still creating stories of your grace and of your light.
Grant us wisdom, grant us courage, for the gifts from one great heart,
For the gifts from one great heart. --lyrics adapted from A. Carmines

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One, it is in the depths of life that we find you,
at the heart of this moment,
at the center of our souls,
deep in the earth and its eternal stirrings.
You are the Ground of all being,
the Well-Spring of all time,
Womb of the earth,
and the Seed-Force of stars.
And so at the opening of this day
we wait,
not for blessings from afar,
but for You,
the very Soil of our soul,
the early Freshness of morning,
the first Breath of this Day.
[JPhilipNewell]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Kyrie" from Requiem
Cathedral Choir

MAURICE DURUFLÉ

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Schiefelbein

Our God...who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kindom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.

Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.

*And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

In the rising of the sun and its setting,
in the glow of the moon and its seasons,
in the infinity of space and its shining stars,
we experience God with gratitude.

This morning, may we know the harmony of heaven
in the relationships of earth,
and may we know the expanse of its mystery
within ourselves and with each other.

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from our Religious Tradition *from Psalm 18*

Rev. Schiefelbein

This is the Wisdom of Life.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal Mystery, Heaven's Presence,
Stillest Breath and Deepest Sigh,
we open our hearts
to the presence of who we are.
Each of us brings life to this day's possibilities.
We bring hope, or despair,
eagerness or malaise,
joy or sorrow,
and with these things we create the world within us.

May the beauty of life's fullness unfold in our hearts
that we may loosen
the grip of the mundane on our lives.
May the richness of mystery unfold in our minds
that we may let go of our need for proof.
May the possibility of newness and light
be present to us
that we may unfold the wings of our faith,
and soar as into a world changed by our possibilities.

May we see in the stars, and in each other,
the collective beauty of the universe
and the miracle of our presence in it.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"God Is Seen"
Laude, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Conductor*

ALICE PARKER

Sermon

The Gospel According to Antoni Gaudí

Rev. Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Schiefelbein & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We come to this Table today, awe struck creatures,
conscious that as we travel this short
distance to the bread and the cup,
the whole cosmos – gathered up in us –
journeys with us, and in us,
into the sanctifying heart and mind
of Jesus the Christ.

So, we take these gifts of the earth and the work of human hands,
bread and the fruit of the vine, and we give thanks for who we are
and all we have.

We break and share this bread, as Jesus broke and shared it,
mindful of God's presence with us
and our bonding with all people.

We take this cup, mindful of the privilege of human existence
and our ability to appreciate our connectedness
with God, the source of all that exists.

As we eat this bread and drink this cup,
may people see in us, the spirit of appreciation, gratitude,
and generous self-giving we have seen in Jesus.

Prayer of Blessing**Rev. Lehman**

God of Mystery,
present and active on this planet
for billions of years,
you have been in the midst of new beginnings
and, in the constant transformations
of new life and possibilities.

As we take this bread and this cup,
may the story we tell about you,
about our universe,
about all people,
and about ourselves,
heal, guide, and ground
us in the unfolding
of this continuing mystery.
Amen and Amen.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity**Rev. Lehman**

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Oy Es Dia de Placer"
Cathedral Choir

THOMÁS PASCUAL

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

Prayer of Offering*Rev. Schiefelbein**

O God of the Universe,
we give thanks today
for the Driving Force
at work in our world
that becomes visible
in extravagant generosity
and celebration of being.

We rejoice in the awareness
that we are co-creators with you
of this life
and we pray for the grace
to accept its responsibilities.

Help us in these days to work with
the Spirit of Life so that we may
give breath to your dream
for our lives, and for our world.
We pray this in remembrance of the One
who shows us the way.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Holiness, in which we live,
help us feel our tomorrows
stirring in our hearts this day.

Feel the strength of the dream we have yet to live;
feel the courage of the day we have yet to face.
*Feel the peace of the heart we have yet to heal
and the release of the tears we have yet to shed.*
Feel the hope of the promise we have yet to hear
and the warmth of the embrace we have yet to feel.
On this day, we claim the hope of all that will be.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Señor, me has mirado a los ojos"
Cathedral Choir

CESÁREO GABARAÍN

*"God, you have searched me and while smiling, have spoken my name.
Now my boat's left on the shore behind me. By your side I will seek other seas."*

***Hymn for the Journey**

Creator of All Time and Space

TALLIS' CANON

Creator of all time and space, we read your image on each face.
Great Spirit of the cosmic whole, you made us body, mind, and soul.

We thank you for the human mind, in mystic harmony designed,
For word and image, dream and thought, for lessons learned and answers sought.

O God of planet, moon, and sun, we wonder, knowing all you've done,
That you befriend the human race, and fill our lives with love and grace.

For miracles as large as space, as small as cells, as deep as grace,
We offer you our thanks and praise, and pledge to serve you all our days.
-lyrics by Ruth C. Duck

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Paseo de Gracia from *Gaudi* (Parsons/Woolfson)

Inside The Music

“As we celebrate the work of Gaudi, and Hispanic Heritage Month, we sing a piece by 17th Century Guatemalan composer, Tomás Pascual. Like many of his colleagues, Pascual was a Mayan native who became well known in the Spanish colonies as an accomplished musician and leader. His “Oy Es Dia de Placer” follows rhythmic and melodic patterns of the time. It is fervently rhythmic, involving the numerous percussion elements available to Spanish colonial churches. It has a lilt and drive to it common to the Spanish villancico, and influenced by the music of his Mayan culture. As we have explored over the past few years, the music of his time speaks with a multi-cultural vocabulary. It sounds European to someone versed in that music, but is rich in new ways that are unique to the Americas. We’ll also sing a bit of Duruflé’s “Kyrie” in honor of Gaudi’s devout Catholicism. Gaudi speaks of his cathedral design as being of nature, even resembling a forest of trees. Duruflé’s “Requiem” has similar earth-inspired qualities. A colleague of mine once said that his music feels like being suspended under water. It flows and moves with such grace that it induces images of nature into our imagination.” Dr. David Harris

“Alice Parker (1925 - 2023) and Robert Shaw (1916 - 1999) arranged two hundred carols, early American folk hymns, love songs, sea shanties, glee club songs, spirituals, and Stephen Foster songs. Because of Shaw’s more famous name, the arrangements were listed under “Shaw-Parker.” However, Alice Parker did most of the actual arranging with editorial oversight by Shaw. She did this while raising five children!

To save on costs, most of the arrangements were based on melodies in the public domain and scored for a cappella singers, thus avoiding royalty fees and the cost of hiring instrumentalists. They continue to be well loved by choirs throughout the world for their accessibility to a wide range of ability levels, their musical interest and their simple elegance.” -Grace Sheldon-Williams